Total Communication

Total Communication is an approach that uses and values all forms of communication. Instead of relying on a single method like speech, it encourages the use of a wide range of options to help individuals express themselves and be understood.

Why Total Communication?

Everyone deserves a voice

Because there is no one 'right way' to communicate

Reduce frustration

Provides multiple means and opportunities for someone to express themselves

Genuine connection

Honouring and respecting different communication styles builds trust and genuine connection

Promotes independence

Enables individuals to participate more fully making it easier for them to make choices and have autonomy over their life

Enhances social interaction

Supports the building and maintaining of relationships and facilitation of two-way conversations

Supports language development

Builds a foundation for both expressive and receptive communication skills

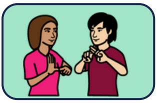
Key elements of a Total Communication approach

VISUAL AIDS

Pictures, symbols, visual timetables, now/next boards, task planners/breakdowns

BODY LANGUAGE AND GESTURE

Facial expression, gesture, tone of voice



SIGNING SYSTEMS

Systems such as Makaton or Signalong

ASSISTIVE TECHNOLOGY

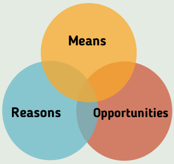
Communication apps or devices

Communication –Key considerations

Creating a supportive environment is crucial for the success of individuals with communication needs, especially those who use augmentative and alternative communication (AAC). This is also a key factor for ensuring their meaningful participation in research.

The Means, Reasons and Opportunities model (Money and Thurman, 1994)

The Means, Reasons, and Opportunities model suggests that a supportive environment is essential for effective communication.



Means: Their method of communication, such as speech, gestures, or an AAC device.
Reasons: Their motivation or desire to communicate, like expressing needs or opinions.
Opportunities: The chance to communicate with others throughout the day.

Physical environment

Make sure the right resources are available

Consider and provide AAC resources that match an individual's cognitive, linguistic, and physical abilities. These tools should enhance their communication and support their understanding.

Consider the space

The physical environment should be comfortable, accessible, and free of distractions. Before facilitating sessions, an understanding of the individual's sensory needs should be gained. Adjustments such as lighting, minimising background noise, and optimising seating arrangements can then be made.

Communication partners

Patience

AAC users, or individuals with communication difficulties, often need more time to process and create a message, so it's important to wait without interrupting or changing the subject. It is essential that we do not insist the person uses their AAC to communicate. We should accept all communication, however it is expressed and however long it takes to convey the message.

Repair strategies

If we don't understand an individual's message, it's key to not pretend that we do. Asking the individual to repeat themselves, or to clarify, is important. If the individual does not understand the communication partner's message, use shorter and clearer sentences.

Modelling

The most effective way to fully embed AAC is to use it yourself and show the individual that you value it as a valid form of communication. Modelling involves speaking and simultaneously pointing to the symbols or words on the individual's AAC system (if they are happy with this) as you interact with them.

UNAIDED AAC

Unaided AAC refers to communication which does not require any external tools or devices. The individual uses their own body to communicate.

Examples of unaided AAC includes...

- Gestures: Pointing, waving, or giving a thumbs-up. These are deliberate actions.
- Facial Expressions: Smiling, frowning, or raising eyebrows to show emotion or intent.
- Body Language: Shrugging shoulders to indicate "I don't know" or stomping a foot to express frustration.
- Manual Signs: Formalised sign languages like British Sign Language (BSL), as well as sign-supported speech systems like Makaton.

Examples of commonly used sign systems...

Makaton is a sign system developed to support spoken language for those with learning disabilities and complex communication needs. Signing is used alongside speech, in spoken word order.

Only the key parts of sentences are signed. Makaton also provides a symbol system. Makaton is used widely across many specialist settings in the UK.

Signalong is a sign-supported system also commonly used by those with learning disabilities or communication difficulties. Again, this system follows spoken word order with an emphasis upon key words.

Non-powered AAC

Low-tech or non-powered Alternative and Augmentative Communication systems include those which do not need power to work. They use basic equipment such as symbol books, objects or pen and paper. Below are some key considerations to make before introducing low-tech AAC to support an individual

Considerations to make

Access - Can they reach out to touch a symbol? Can they isolate a finger? Can they use another body part to do so (e.g. eye pointing)? Do they have any visual/hearing difficulties?

Language skills - Can they spell? Would they need both symbols and words? How many symbols can they manage on one page?

What, if any, system are they already familiar with? What do they prefer?

Why Low-Tech AAC?

- Individuals' preference (this is always the most important thing)
- Can be used in environments in which high-tech AAC is not appropriate, e.g. in the bath or swimming pool
- Can be more natural/less effortful for the individual and a quicker way to get their point across
- More robust, accessible and low-priced

Examples of Low-Tech AAC systems

- Communication book
- Talking Mats
- Visual Scene Displays
- E-Tran Frames (or eye gaze boards)

Powered AAC

Powered AAC relies on power to work. They often include devices such as computers and tablets and run software vocabularies.

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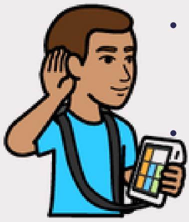
Language skills - Can they spell? Would they need both symbols and words? How many symbols can they manage on one page?

What, if any, system are they already familiar with? What do they prefer?

Why Powered AAC?

- Individuals' preference (this is always the most important thing)
- Provides a wider choice of vocabulary
- Is easier to update/make edits on the go
- Supports a wider variety of communicative functions (e.g. greeting, refusing, commenting, questioning)
- Typically generates speech output (synthesised speech)
- Systems are often robust enough to develop and grow with the individual
- Digital storage for thousands of words

Examples of powered AAC systems



- Computers
- Tablets with specific communication software programmed on them (e.g. Proloquo2go, Grid)
- Dedicated Speech Generating device